



Q: Which movement did he launch after Independence?

A: The Aikya Kerala or United Kerala

Q: He was defeated only once in general elections. When?

A: In 1952 by K.P. Kuttikrishnan Nair

Q: He was the editor of which publication?

A: The Left newspaper, *Deshabhimani*

Q: What was he affectionately called at home?

A: Kunju, the little one

Q: Which novel did he criticise for its 'deviant' sexuality?

A: *The God of Small Things*



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world's first democratically-elected Marxist government in Kerala. It is a testimony to his commitment to democracy that he never got carried away by the euphoria over its formation. As chief minister, his first proclamation was that his government would not attempt to bring about socialism. Instead it would try to mitigate the miseries faced by common people. Even during those days EMS showed boldness in inviting private entrepreneurs to invest in the state.

Born and brought up in an orthodox Brahmin family, EMS's baptism in public life was by fighting the regressive ways of his own community. After a boyhood spent among scriptures, he chose to walk to the other end. The scion of a rich feudal family, he took the lead in ending landlordism. In the Congress, he fought against the dominant ideologies to give birth to the Communist party; within the Communist party he kept democracy alive and waged an unrelenting struggle against its Right and Left forces.

His first ministry's greatest achievement was in universal literacy, gender justice, public health and comprehensive land reforms which revolutionised the society in Kerala and tore up its feudal fabric. A true Renaissance man, EMS not only rewrote the state's political and social equations but his positions have also remained reference points on subjects like the arts, culture, literature and philosophy.

EMS could be credited with being one of the architects of CPI(M)'s independent line which militated against both the Right and Left forces that pulled the party. CPI's illusions vanished with the onset of Emergency when its ally, the Congress, shed its democratic facade and revealed its dictatorial fangs. On the other side, the Naxalite movement fizzled out as its bankrupt and militant politics were exposed where ever the CPI (M) was dominant. EMS's tenure as the party general secretary from 1978 to the late '80s witnessed the party weathering its worst crisis when it was subjected to persecution by both

the Right and the Left within the country and assault from the Soviet Union and China internationally.

In the late '80s, poor health and advancing age made EMS return to Kerala for a well-earned rest and recuperation. But instead he set himself another busy agenda. Through his writings, he gave a clarion call to Keralites to rise above their differences over caste, religion and politics. His final days were devoted to the People's Planning Programme, India's most comprehensive decentralisation programme.

One of the legitimate criticisms against EMS was his reluctance to theorise innovative experiments which formulated Indian Communist practice. Though a prolific writer, whose collected works are to come out in 150 volumes, he is often accused of sticking to positions dubbed dogmatic. But then, hasn't the absence of theory been more than compensated by his praxis?

The writer is a CPI(M) ideologue and a former editor of Deshabhimani